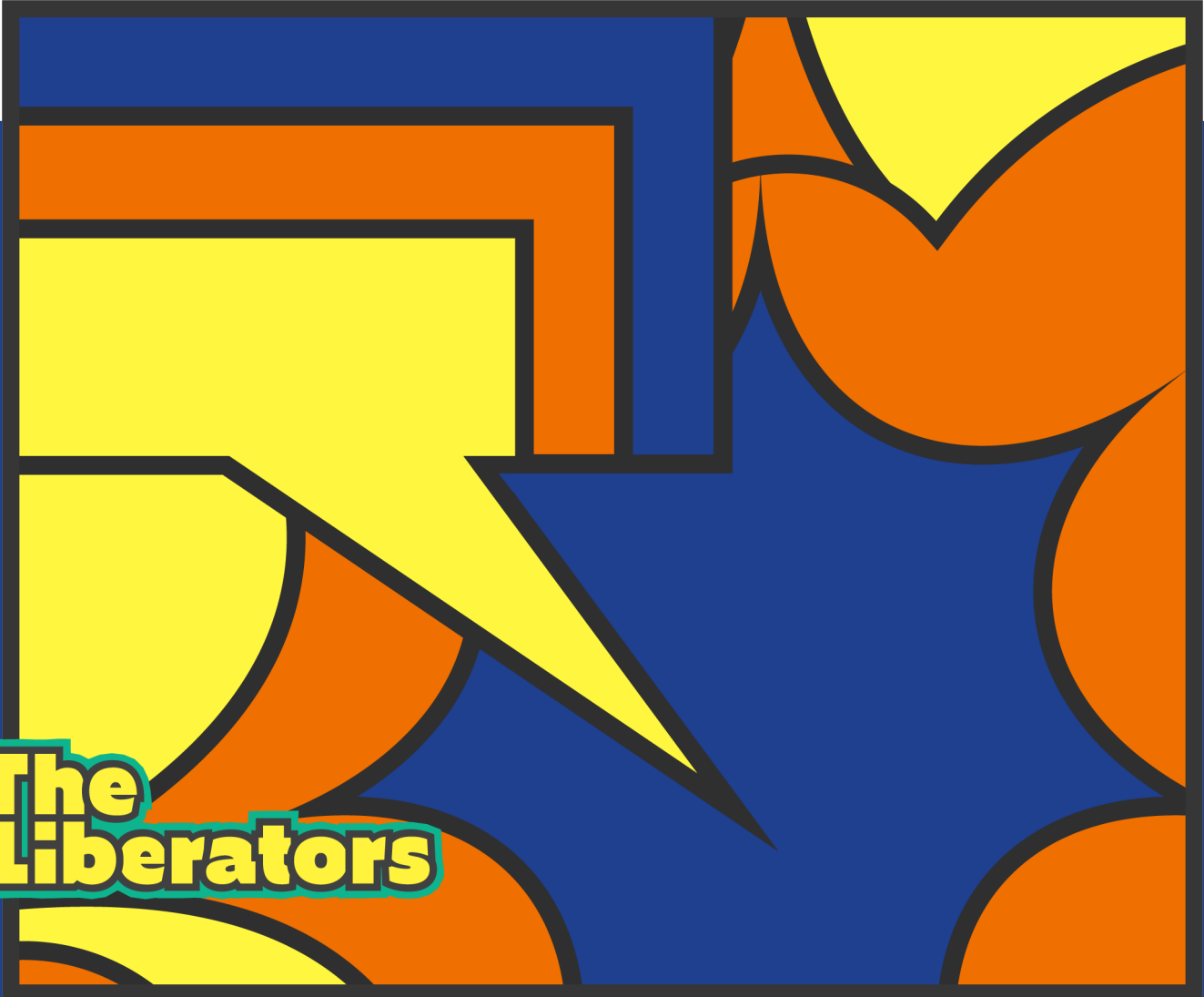


Determine What Is Valuable With Your Team And Stakeholders

A simple experiment to make transparent what "value" means to your team and its stakeholders, and to maximize the value of your work together



**The
Liberators**

Purpose Of This Experiment

Hey there!

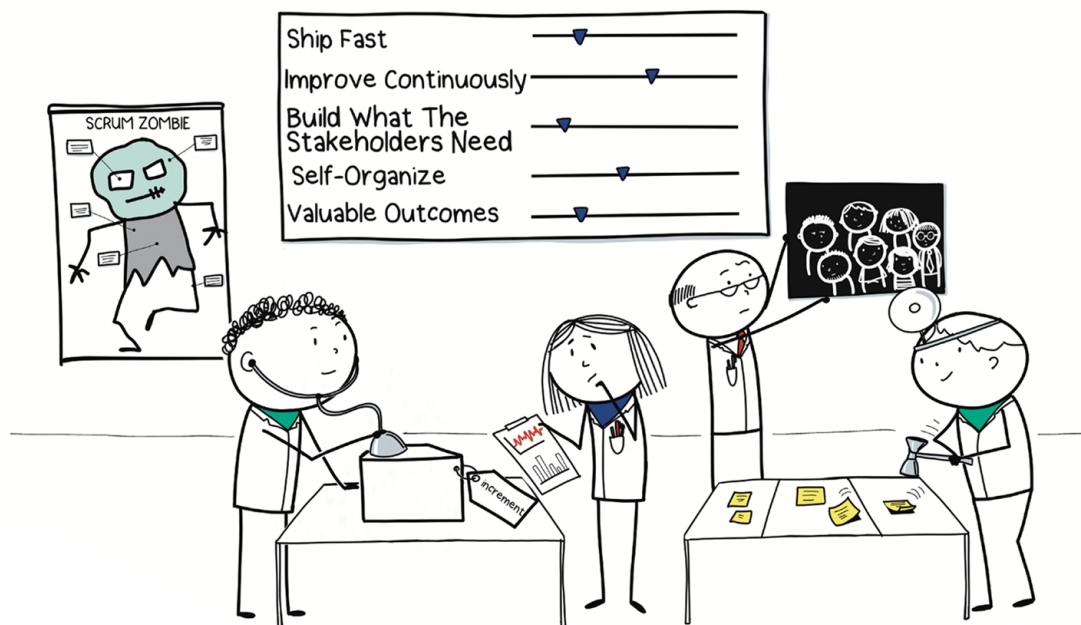
The Scrum framework exists to deliver value to stakeholders sooner. Sounds good, right? But when is something "valuable"? For something that seems so central to Scrum, there is little guidance on what "value" means. And that easily leads to Zombie Scrum, where teams are incredibly busy with work that is of no value and no consequence.

This experiment exists to start a conversation around "value" with your team and its stakeholders. You can embed this into a regular Sprint Planning, a Sprint Review, or a Sprint Retrospective. Or even as a separate workshop.

Give it a try and let us know how it went!

Barry & Christiaan

The Liberators



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem
zombiescrum.org

Difficulty / Effort

Required Skill



The biggest challenge is to bring stakeholders into this experiment

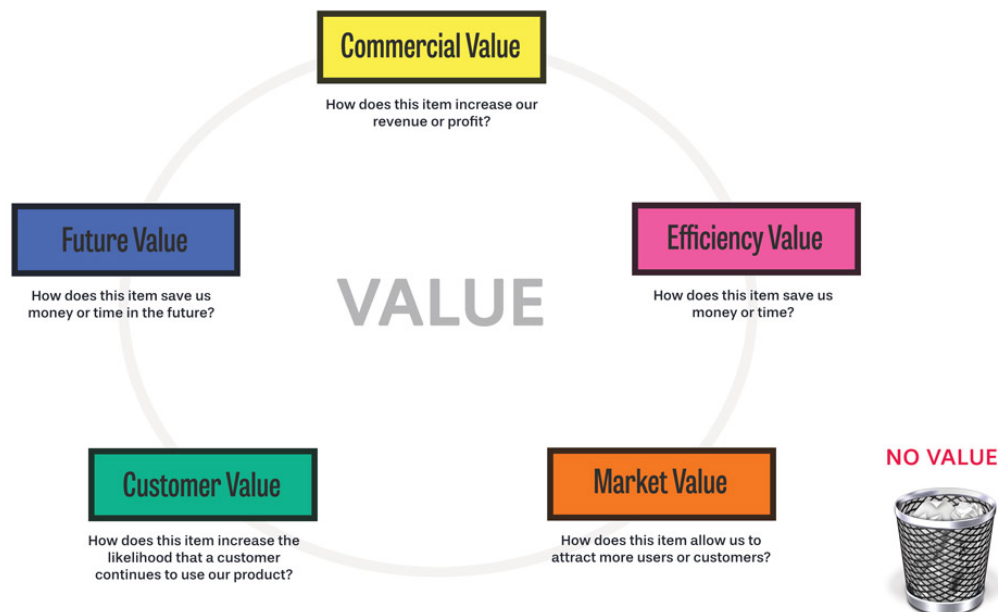
Impact On Survival



Starting the conversation about "value" often amounts to a landslide shift in how teams maximize the value of their work.

Five Types Of Value

For each item on your Product Backlog, together distribute 100 points over the five types of value – or the trashcan.



Based on blogpost
<http://bit.ly/lt-value>
Created by
Christiaan Verwijs
creative commons 4.0



In our work with Scrum teams, and while developing products, we've noticed that "value" often takes many shapes. It helps to be explicit about what kind of value is represented on your Product Backlog. From the perspective of the Product Goal that your team uses, you can categorize items into five types:

- **Commercial Value** concerns items that directly increase revenue or profit. For example, an item generates commercial value when – upon its delivery – customers pay to acquire it. This could be a new version of your product, a new feature, or an unlockable add-on. It could also be a new bit of paid downloadable content, a new product in your webshop, or something else that customers pay for directly. Although there may be some layers between the delivery and the payment, we like to think about these items as the lines that appear on an invoice that is sent to a customer.
- **Efficiency Value** concerns items that simplify, automate, reduce, or smoothen other work. These are the items that improve your cost efficiency by spending less money for the same amount of value that is delivered to stakeholders. Automation is a good example of this category, but so is the optimization of processes that would otherwise a lot of people or manual work.
- **Market Value** concerns items that primarily intend to increase awareness of your product, to move into new markets, or to distinguish from competing products. Marketing activities are a good example of this kind of work, but so is the inclusion of unique features that competitors don't have. The key question is "How does this item allow us to attract more users or customers?"
- **Customer Value** covers items that primarily exist to keep customers satisfied with your product. User experience optimization is a good example of work in this category, but so is the inclusion of often-requested features that

customers don't directly pay for. The key question is: "How does this item increase the likelihood that a customer continues to use our product?".

- **Future Value** concerns items that don't deliver any value immediately on their completion, but are important hedges against future problems. The reduction of technical debt can be a good example of this, but so is research & innovation.

This taxonomy is certainly not complete. The various types overlap in several ways, and some items may not fall clearly into any type – and still be valuable.

But the point is that you should have a conversation with your team and your stakeholders about what makes each item on your Product Backlog valuable. For items where you can easily categorize them into one or more of these types, you're probably dealing with something valuable. If you can't, your team, and especially your Product Owner, needs to have an exceptionally compelling reason for why it is still on the Product Backlog. After all, how does a Product Owner maximize the value of the work done by the Scrum team by keeping items around that are seemingly non-valuable?

Steps

1. This experiment requires items from your current Product Backlog. So either bring the top 10–20 items or bring your entire Product Backlog. Invite important stakeholders to attend. It is really hard, and quite unwise, to determine the value of your work without involving those you're doing it for.
2. **2 min** Begin by clarifying the purpose of this experiment. You will be working together to clarify the value of the items on the Product Backlog, and make adaptations where necessary.
3. **5 min** Invite the Product Owner to briefly explain the five types of value. Give some examples, preferably ones that are recognizable for the participants, and answer urgent questions. Also clarify the purpose of the trashcan in the model, which represents "no value" (or highly unclear), at least for the purpose you have for the product.
4. **10 min** Ask everyone present to silently and individually distribute 100 points of value across the five types or the trashcan from their perspective and do so for each item that you prepared. For example, one item can have 100 points of "commercial value" while another can have 20 points of "efficiency value", 10 points of "market value", and 70 points remaining in "no value". Encourage people not to overthink it, and follow their initial intuitions.
5. **20 min** Invite everyone into small groups, mixing team members and stakeholders where possible. In their groups, invite people to share their scores, notice patterns, and discuss substantial differences. Ask each group to converge at one distribution of scores for each item that they all feel comfortable enough with by the end of this round.
6. **5 min** Ask the groups to enter their scores into a prepared spreadsheet or matrix on a shared surface or workspace, allowing everyone to see differences and similarities.
7. **10 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently reflect on the invitation: "In order to maximize the value of our work, which items can be safely removed?" **1 min** and then discuss it with the group **9 min**. Capture recommendations;
8. **10 min** Ask everyone to individually and silently reflect on the invitation: "What other adaptations should we make to the Product Backlog in order to maximize the value of our work?" **1 min** and then discuss it with the group **9 min**. What is missing? What should be ordered differently? Capture important adaptations.

Our Findings



- Many organizations have designed work in such a way that the value of that work is not often a topic for debate. So you may find that teams and their stakeholders struggle to think in terms of value at all. If you do, this is a great topic for an in-the-moment retrospective. If it is completely unclear what value means to your team, and even its stakeholders, how can you ever be effective?
- If you're running this experiment virtually, you can create a shared Google Spreadsheet where the groups can enter their scores. Keep the individual round individual though; as seeing other scores may influence people.
- It might be tempting to get stuck in deep discussions around individual items. Other items may be very unclear. Since this experiment is more concerned with the larger patterns, and what they mean for your work together, we recommend moving detailed discussions about individual items into separate gatherings. If many items lead to strong debates, this is a sign that you may need to converse more about your Product Backlog.

More Resources

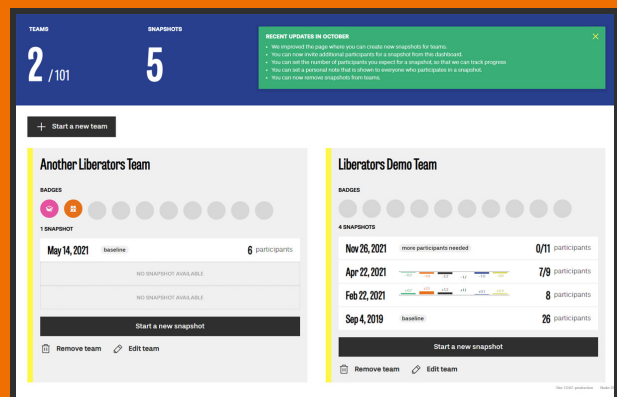
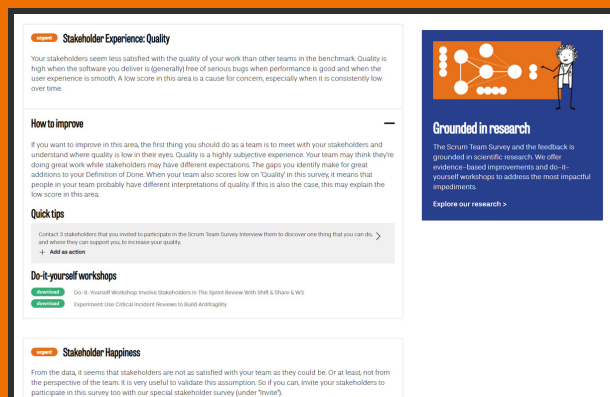
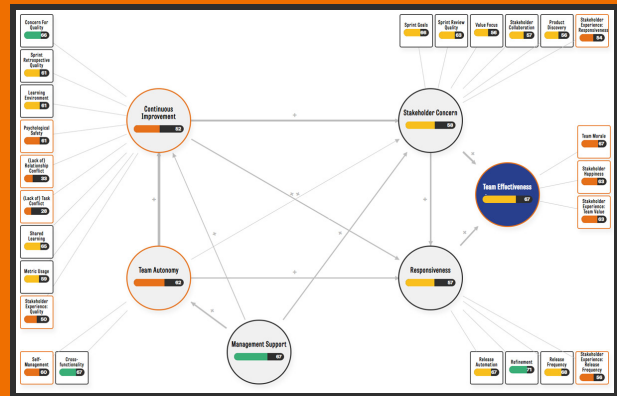
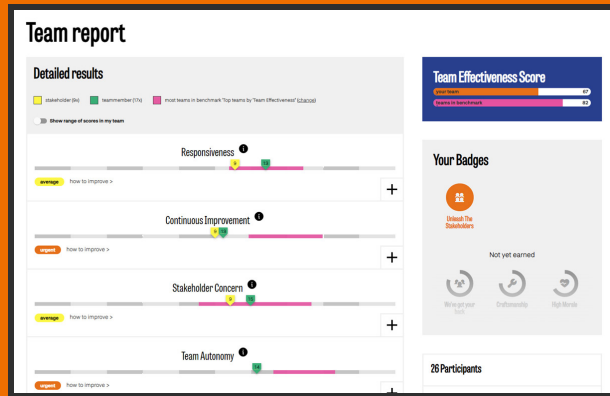


- Blog post: [Five Types Of Value](#)
- Canvas: [Five Types Of Value \(PDF\)](#)
- Myth: Only The Product Owner Interacts With Stakeholders. Read the [blog post](#) or listen to the [podcast episode](#)
- Blog post: [Why Zombie Scrum Teams Don't Involve Stakeholders](#)
- Podcast: [The Curious Case of the Missing Stakeholders](#)



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	Essential	Liberator
Invite team members & stakeholders	unlimited	unlimited
Quick Tips for your team per topic	3	unlimited
Recommendations to your team	5	unlimited
Compare your team against different benchmarks		✓
Analyze the range of scores in your team		✓
Receive our personal guidance on how to get started		✓
See where your team improves over time with Team Trends		✓
Support our academic research to help more teams		✓
Pricing per team per month	€ 0	€ 10

<https://scrumteamsurvey.org>

info@scrumteamsurvey.org

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